THREAT OF A NEW STRAIN

"Covid will not go away after Omicron. More variants will come up," asserts Dr Rajeev Jayadevan, an epidemiologist and former head of the IMA (Indian Medical Association). Researchers have even fixed a date for the new wave's arrival—June 22—as well as the length of its stay—till October 24. This is what IIT Kanpur researchers predicted and published on the preprint server MedRxiv on February 24, using a statistical model. Its severity, though, will depend on the emergence of new variants.

With the virus exhibiting 10 major variants already, a new variant of concern is likely to come up in either of two ways—as an altogether fresh strain, or as a sub-strain of an existing variant. In fact, a sub-strain of the original BA.1 variant, which accounted for more than 98 per cent of Omicron cases, is already doing the rounds. Christened BA.2, it has quickly become the dominant strain in Denmark. Even though it is believed to be more infectious, it is not expected to trigger another wave because, as Dr Jayadevan points out, "those who have had BA.1 will be immune to it or have a very mild disease". However, over time, the antibody count of those who have been infected with Omicron could go down, leaving them vulnerable to another Covid attack. And while it may not prove deadly, it could be like getting Omicron all over again. BA.2 may not be of concern today but could well become a variant of concern in a few months, particularly since lab studies in Denmark, which have analysed data from 8,500 Danish households, indicated it to be 33 per cent more infectious than BA.1. The sub-variant is also unresponsive to treatments like monoclonal antibodies and exhibits immune escape properties.

THE NEXT VARIANT COULD BE WEAK LIKE OMICRON, AFFECTING ONLY THE UPPER RESPIRATORY TRACT, OR STRONG LIKE DELTA, INFECTING THE LUNG



"RNA viruses never stop mutating; it is how they survive," says Dr Rakesh Mishra, director of the Tata Institute for Genetics and Society in Bengaluru. The mutation itself is not the threat, it is how it manifests clinically that causes concern. "In its Omicron avatar, the virus was milder but more infectious," says Mishra. "It is trying to find ways to keep infecting humans, particularly since most of us are now vaccinated against it. Omicron's sub-variant is more infectious than the original. The next mutation could be even more infectious, have greater immune escape, or lead to more serious disease. It is uncertain which way Covid will mutate to survive."

What is certain though is that vaccines will remain our best armour against infections, serious disease and the emergence of new variants. "We will eventually need boosters for everyone in India," says Dr Rahul Pandit, member of the Maharashtra Covid task force. "Omicron has shown that the virus is finding ways to escape the immune defences of human beings. So, we must boost those defences from time to time."

NEW PILLS ON THE BLOCK

Brijesh Kumar, a 39-year-old businessman in Delhi, contracted Covid in both the second and the third wave. Both times his infection was mild. However, there was a huge difference in the number of drugs he had to take each time, he says. "The first time I had eight different medicines to take, including four multivitamins. There was sheer confusion about what medicine was needed. Different doctors would advise different drugs," he says. "But with Omicron, it was simple–only paracetamol, vitamin C and zinc supplements and lots of fluid intake." While medication alone may not end the pandemic, it will remain vital in its management. India's treatment protocol has strengthened with every wave. "Our treatment of Covid has advanced significantly over the past two years," says Dr Sandeep Budhiraja, medical director of the Max healthcare group. "If the Covid surge was mild this year, it is also because of growing awareness and medical options. Future waves too will